



For the President
22 September 2026

Today's Brief

US-CHINA / AI: Washington and Beijing agree a first channel to flag dangerous AI incidents, days before the Trump-Xi summit.

GERMANY: AfD wins an eastern state vote as the Chancellor's CDU is shut out entirely.

UKRAINE: Russia strikes the south after Kyiv's record drone barrage; a Trump-Zelensky meeting is set for New York.

IRAN: Washington and Tehran trade war threats on the eve of the UN gathering.

NORTH KOREA: Two ballistic launches prompt trilateral allied consultations.

UNGA: High-level week opens with roughly 130 leaders and a crowded presidential schedule.

NOTES: Energy and markets, the first island chain, and the widening Yemen war.

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US and China Agree To First Channel for Flagging Dangerous AI Incidents

We assess that the "USA-China AI Dialogue" unveiled on 21 September — including a proposed "incident line" for AI events that reach a national-security threshold — is a modest but potentially significant confidence-building step between the world's two leading AI powers. It is intended to reduce the risk of miscalculation rather than to constrain either side's programs, and it lands two days before the scheduled Trump-Xi summit. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said he established the channel with Chinese Vice Premier He Lifeng after an eight-hour meeting in New York on 20 September.

- The mechanism would create a recurring dialogue and a notification or "incident line" for alarming episodes — Bessent cited runaway AI agents, AI-enabled cyberattacks, and biological-weapons uplift — but it is **not yet operational**: thresholds, participants, and protocols remain undefined, and officials plan to reconvene in Shenzhen in roughly two months.
- Beijing's public readout confirmed an AI dialogue but did not endorse the incident-line specifics. We judge China likely sees value in a channel that signals responsibility while avoiding binding limits on its own compute or model development.
- For Washington, the near-term value is crisis communication, not verification: absent agreed definitions and technical means, the channel cannot independently confirm the other side's claims and will be only as useful as each government's willingness to use it candidly.
- We assess the announcement also positions both leaders ahead of the summit later this week, letting each point to cooperation on AI safety while the hard issues — export controls, advanced chips, Taiwan, and trade — remain unresolved.

A decision point comes at the planned Shenzhen follow-on: whether the two sides can agree even a narrow, workable definition of a reportable "incident" and stand up a functioning channel, or whether the dialogue stalls as a diplomatic gesture. We will watch for any joint language on AI at the summit itself.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, NSA, INR, Treasury OIA, and open sources.

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Far-Right AfD Wins East German State Vote as Chancellor's Party Is Shut Out

We assess that the Alternative for Germany's first-place finish in Mecklenburg-Vorpommern on 20 September — and the unprecedented shutout of Chancellor Friedrich Merz's Christian Democrats — deepens the pressure on Berlin's governing center and confirms the continued erosion of Germany's mainstream parties in the east, even though the standing "firewall" against cooperation with the AfD will keep it out of the state government.

- Official results: AfD 38.2% (32 seats) and the SPD 35.5% (29), with the CDU collapsing to 4.9% and winning **no seats** — the first time the party has ever failed to enter a German state parliament. The SPD is expected to form a left-leaning coalition despite the AfD's plurality.
- Merz called the result "disastrous" but vowed to stay on as Chancellor. We judge the outcome weakens his standing inside the CDU and complicates his federal coalition with the SPD without immediately threatening the government.
- For Washington, the trend matters most for burden-sharing. A governing center squeezed by an AfD that is skeptical of Ukraine aid and higher NATO spending — and by a strengthening left — could narrow Berlin's room to sustain its defense build-up and support for Kyiv.

We expect the AfD to press its momentum into next year's contests. The question for US planners is whether Merz can hold his coalition together and protect Germany's defense-spending trajectory through a difficult political stretch.

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Russia Strikes Southern Ukraine After Kyiv's Record Drone Barrage

We assess that the weekend's exchange — a Ukrainian long-range drone campaign of more than 1,000 aircraft, including what Kyiv called its largest-ever strike on Moscow, answered by Russian strikes on Zaporizhzhia and other regions on 21 September — reflects an intensifying deep-strike war that neither side is winning outright, even as both position for possible contacts at this week's UN gathering.

- Russian strikes on 21 September hit Zaporizhzhia and other areas, damaging residential buildings, a university facility, and a shopping center and wounding several people; a separate strike in Kharkiv region killed one. President Zelensky said Moscow "is not backing down from its escalation" and is signaling readiness to widen the war.
- Ukraine's campaign against Russian refining continues to bite. We assess Ukrainian strikes have removed a substantial share of Russia's refining throughput this year, feeding domestic fuel shortages. Overhead imagery shows fire damage and idled units at several refineries struck in recent weeks.
- Zelensky said he expects to meet President Trump in New York this week. We judge the meeting is aimed at reviving a US-brokered track frozen for months, with no sign yet of terms either capital would accept.

A near-term decision point is whether a Trump-Zelensky meeting produces movement toward trilateral talks with Moscow, or whether both belligerents conclude the battlefield still rewards waiting. We expect continued reciprocal deep strikes on energy and defense-industrial targets in the interim.

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US and Iran Trade War Threats on the Eve of the UN Gathering

We assess the sharp exchange of threats between Washington and Tehran over the weekend raises the risk of renewed direct conflict, even as both governments leave a diplomatic door ajar at the UN General Assembly. President Trump warned that Iran would "fail economically" or see its leadership destroyed absent a deal; Iran's Khatam al-Anbiya central headquarters warned it would retaliate "without limits" against US bases across the region if strikes resume.

- The rhetoric follows this year's US-Israeli air campaign against Iran and a continuing US pressure posture. Iranian officials claim to have intelligence that Washington and regional partners are preparing a fresh wave of strikes — a claim we **cannot corroborate** from open sources and treat with caution.
- President Pezeshkian is due in New York, and Trump has said he is open to meeting him; at the same time the US denied visas to part of the Iranian delegation, a friction point that complicates any sideline diplomacy.
- Trump is scheduled to meet Gulf Arab leaders this week on the "next phase" of the Iran confrontation. We judge the Gulf states will press for de-escalation given their exposure to Iranian and Houthi retaliation.

For Washington, the key question is whether UN-week contacts open a negotiating path or merely set the stage for the next round. Watch whether a Trump-Pezeshkian meeting materializes and whether either side softens preconditions — Tehran is demanding relief from sanctions and an end to what it calls a naval blockade on its oil exports.

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North Korea Fires Two Ballistic Missiles; Seoul, Washington, and Tokyo Consult

We assess that Pyongyang's launch of two short-range ballistic missiles on 20 September — and the trilateral consultations among Seoul, Washington, and Tokyo that followed on 21 September — fit a familiar pattern of pressure timed to allied military activity rather than signaling an imminent shift, though the tempo of testing this year is notable.

- South Korea's military reported two launches within about three hours, flying roughly 450 and more than 600 kilometers into the East Sea; allied sensors tracked both. The launches bring Pyongyang's total this year to at least 15, according to Japan's defense minister.
- The launches followed North Korean complaints about US-South Korean military drills. We judge Pyongyang is calibrating provocations to register displeasure while preserving room to maneuver.
- For Washington, the value of the trilateral call is signaling alliance cohesion. We expect continued short-range testing and cannot rule out a longer-range event if Pyongyang seeks attention during UN-week diplomacy.

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World Leaders Convene in New York as UN High-Level Week Opens

We assess that the opening of the UN General Assembly's high-level week — with roughly 130 heads of state and government and more than 1,000 requested bilateral meetings — will serve this year less as a forum for breakthroughs than as a venue for managing overlapping crises: the Iran confrontation, the war in Ukraine, and US-China competition. Brazil's President Lula opens the general debate on 22 September, with President Trump due to address the assembly.

- The President's schedule this week includes bilaterals with Ukraine's Zelensky, UK Prime Minister Starmer, and Gulf Arab leaders on Iran, plus the summit with China's Xi. We judge the administration will use the week to press its "peace through strength" framing and pursue sideline deals rather than multilateral commitments.
- The session's formal theme is "restoring trust"; the practical test is whether UN-week contacts cool the US-Iran and Russia-Ukraine tracks even marginally.

Watch the Trump-Zelensky meeting, any Trump-Pezeshkian contact, and the Trump-Xi summit later in the week for whether diplomacy gains traction or the week ends as choreography.

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Notes

- **Energy and markets.** Brent crude is hovering near \$100-102 a barrel, with a risk premium sustained by Houthi attacks on Saudi oil infrastructure. Gold eased toward the low-\$4,300s after the Federal Reserve raised rates last week and signaled at least one more increase in 2026. We assess near-term energy risk is now driven more by Gulf security than by Russia sanctions, though the newly enacted Graham Act's secondary-sanction tools could tighten Russian export flows over time.
- **The first island chain.** Visiting Japanese lawmakers and US members of Congress agreed on 21 September that the United States and Japan must be prepared to defend the first island chain, including Taiwan. We assess the statement reflects legislative sentiment and allied signaling rather than a policy shift, but it underscores steady bipartisan and allied focus on deterring Beijing.
- **The widening Yemen war.** Houthi missile and drone attacks on Saudi targets — including a ballistic missile intercepted near Riyadh and strikes claimed against Aramco facilities on 19 September — have broadened the conflict. US diplomatic posts in the region have urged heightened vigilance and warned of possible airspace closures and flight disruptions.

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